

Guide 3: The Top Zakat-Eligible Charities of 2026

Good Measure Giving

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REVIEW

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TL;DR (shown at top of page)

Out of 95 charities in our database that publicly state they accept zakat, these ten are the top scorers within each major cause area on our evaluation — impact, alignment with Muslim donor priorities, and governance — with high data confidence behind every score. We verify that the zakat claim exists and that the organization checks out; whether a given charity satisfies your school's zakat criteria is a question for you and your scholar. List refreshed annually before Ramadan.

How this list is built

Start with what this list is not: a fatwa. Good Measure Giving tags a charity ZAKAT-ELIGIBLE when the organization itself publicly states that it accepts zakat — a zakat donation option, a zakat policy page, a zakat fund. We verify the claim exists; we do not rule on whether the charity's programs satisfy the fiqh criteria of your school. That judgment belongs to you and the scholars you trust.

From the 95 zakat-accepting charities in our database, this list takes the top scorers in each major cause area on the GMG Score — impact (weighted by what kind of organization it is), alignment with causes urgent to Muslim communities, and governance risk — and keeps only those with high data confidence, meaning the scores rest on verified filings and substantial public information rather than thin marketing copy.

Scores at the top cluster tightly — several of these organizations score within a point of each other — so we group by cause area rather than pretend a #1-versus-#2 ranking means something. A few equally high scorers aren't featured because they serve a single region or a narrower function; their full evaluations are in the database. The right charity for your zakat depends on which need you feel most responsible for, not on decimal places.

Humanitarian and emergency relief

Direct relief to people in crisis is the cause area with the broadest scholarly agreement on zakat use — feeding, sheltering, and treating people who clearly fall within the fuqara and masakin categories. Four organizations stand out this year.

Zakat Foundation of America, founded in 2003 with zakat at the center of its identity, runs direct humanitarian relief and development programs worldwide and publishes a zakat distribution policy. Islamic Relief USA is one of the largest Muslim relief organizations in the country, with domestic and international programs and the reporting infrastructure of a major NGO. Anera has worked in the Middle East since 1968, delivering aid in Palestine, Lebanon, and Jordan with deep on-the-ground operations. BASMAH focuses where fewer donors look: critical relief and long-term support for vulnerable populations including Rohingya refugees.

Also strong in this category: Baitulmaal and Penny Appeal USA, both scoring within a point or two of the leaders.

Education

Education sits in genuinely disputed zakat territory — scholars differ on when schooling for poor students qualifies — but the organizations themselves are among the most rigorous in our database, and many donors direct zakat here under the guidance of scholars who accept it, or give sadaqah instead.

Developments in Literacy operates high-quality schools and teacher training for underserved children in Pakistan, with a deliberate focus on girls' education. The Citizens Foundation USA supports a school network educating 280,000 children — nearly half of them girls — in low-income communities across Pakistan. Both publish the kind of operational and financial detail that makes evaluation straightforward — a transparency standard much of the sector doesn't meet.

Smaller but notable: Iqra Fund and The Noor Project, both scoring at the top of the education group with high data confidence.

Health and medical relief

Medical care for people who cannot afford it maps cleanly onto zakat's purposes when the patients served are poor or displaced — and both featured organizations work primarily in crisis and low-resource settings.

IMANA (Islamic Medical Association of North America) channels the work of Muslim medical professionals — a corps of roughly 500 volunteers — into direct patient care and health programs worldwide, with exceptionally high fundraising efficiency. MedGlobal sends emergency medical teams and builds health-system resilience in conflict zones and disaster regions, work that consistently reaches the displaced and destitute.

Civil rights and community institutions

Whether civil-rights work can take zakat is one of the live disagreements in contemporary fiqh — most scholars restrict zakat to direct material relief for individuals in the asnaf, while some accept advocacy under fi sabilillah or the defense of vulnerable Muslims. We include this category because the organizations score among the strongest in our database and publicly accept zakat; whether to direct your zakat or your sadaqah here is exactly the kind of question to take to your scholar.

CAIR Foundation is the nation's largest Muslim civil-rights and advocacy organization, with a track record in litigation, media accountability, and legal defense. Sadagaat-USA takes a different path to community impact: high-efficiency water, health, and education projects serving marginalized communities, run with notably low overhead.

And a note on the institution closest to home: many donors' best zakat or sadaqah destination is their own community — the mosque that runs a zakat fund, the local social-services organization that knows which families are struggling. National lists like this one are for the portion of your giving that looks outward.

How to use this list

Treat this as a vetted starting point, not a verdict. Before giving zakat to any organization: confirm its current zakat policy on its own website (policies change), check which programs zakat specifically funds and whether the organization segregates zakat from general donations, and — if your school's positions matter to you — ask the organization directly how it handles the questions scholars dispute, like administrative costs and long-term development spending.

If you haven't calculated what you owe yet, our zakat calculator covers cash, gold, stocks, retirement accounts, crypto, business assets, and real estate. And if you want the evaluation method behind these picks, the companion guide on how to evaluate a Muslim charity walks through the full framework.

This list is refreshed annually ahead of each Ramadan as new filings and pipeline data come in. Scores move; the 2026 edition reflects evaluations as of June 2026 and will be refreshed before Ramadan 2027.

Callout boxes (highlighted on page)

What ZAKAT-ELIGIBLE means here — Our tag records a verifiable fact — this charity publicly states it accepts zakat — not a fiqh ruling that its programs satisfy the criteria of any school. Scholars genuinely differ on categories like education, advocacy, and administrative costs. Consult a scholar you trust for binding guidance on your own zakat.

What we have no stake in — Good Measure Giving takes no commission, referral fee, or payment from any charity listed. Rankings come from the same scoring pipeline applied to every organization in our database, and the full methodology is public.

Featured charity cards (linked on page)

- **Zakat Foundation of America** (EIN 36-4476244): Direct humanitarian relief and long-term development worldwide, with zakat at the center of its identity and a published zakat distribution policy.
- **Islamic Relief USA** (EIN 95-4453134): One of the largest Muslim relief organizations in the US — domestic and international humanitarian aid and poverty alleviation programs.
- **American Near East Refugee Aid (Anera)** (EIN 52-0882226): On-the-ground relief and development for refugees and vulnerable communities in Palestine, Lebanon, and Jordan since 1968.
- **BASMAH** (EIN 82-1670588): Critical humanitarian relief and long-term support for vulnerable populations, including Rohingya refugees.
- **Developments in Literacy** (EIN 33-0843213): High-quality schools and teacher training for underserved children in Pakistan, with a focus on girls' education.
- **The Citizens Foundation USA** (EIN 41-2046295): Supports a school network educating 280,000 children — nearly half of them girls — across Pakistan's low-income communities.
- **IMANA** (EIN 36-4166125): Muslim medical professionals delivering direct patient care and health programs worldwide, powered by a large volunteer corps.
- **MedGlobal** (EIN 82-2517347): Emergency medical teams and health-system resilience in conflict zones and disaster-stricken regions.

- **CAIR Foundation** (EIN 77-0646756): Legal defense, advocacy, and civil-rights protection for American Muslims — note the scholarly debate on zakat for advocacy work.
- **Sadagaat-USA** (EIN 47-2864379): High-efficiency water, health, and education initiatives for marginalized communities, run with notably low overhead.

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: How do you know these charities are zakat-eligible?

We verify that each charity publicly states it accepts zakat — a zakat donation option, fund, or policy on its own website. That is a factual check, not a fiqh ruling. Whether an organization's programs satisfy your school's zakat criteria is a question for you and your scholar; our companion guide on zakat eligibility explains the categories and the disputes.

Q: Why isn't a well-known charity I give to on this list?

Three common reasons: it doesn't publicly claim to accept zakat (so it isn't tagged ZAKAT-ELIGIBLE), its public data is too thin for high confidence, or it scored below the cutoff this cycle. Absence is not an accusation — you can look up any charity in our database to see its full evaluation.

Q: Can I split my zakat across several of these charities?

Yes. Scholars broadly permit distributing zakat among multiple eligible recipients, and many recommend it when needs differ. Some advise giving each organization enough to be meaningful rather than fragmenting into trivial amounts.

Q: Is zakat to these organizations tax-deductible too?

All listed organizations are US 501(c)(3) nonprofits, so donations are generally tax-deductible. Tax deductibility and zakat validity are independent questions — one is IRS policy, the other is fiqh — but here they typically coincide.

Q: Should I give zakat before or during Ramadan?

Zakat is due when your wealth has been above nisab for one lunar year — your personal anniversary date, which may fall in any month. Many people deliberately align payment with Ramadan for the multiplied reward of giving in that month, which is permissible and common; what matters is not delaying past your due date.

Q: When will the 2027 edition be published?

We refresh this list annually before Ramadan, when new IRS filings and our latest evaluation data are in. The scores behind it update continuously on each charity's page in the meantime.

Sources & further reading (as shown on page)

Preceded on the page by: "This guide presents broadly held positions in Sunni fiqh and names the schools where they differ. The references below are where we drew them from. None of this is a fatwa."

- **Zakat Eligibility of Islamic Organizations**, Dr. Hatem al-Haj (AMJA), via MuslimMatters — https://muslimmatters.org/2021/07/20/zakat-eligibility-of-islamic-organizations/SMART-PANTS_RESERVED_188 The contemporary scholarly debate behind the disputed categories (education, advocacy) noted in this list.
- **Refugee Zakat Fund — FAQs**, UNHCR — https://zakat.unhcr.org/en/faqSMARTPANTS_RESERVED_196 Fatwas from 16+ institutions authorizing zakat for refugees — context for the humanitarian and refugee-focused organizations here.
- **Our methodology**, Good Measure Giving — </methodology> How the GMG Score behind this list is computed.